

E

Information Gathering & Discovery

The intelligence work that happens before a single word of the proposal is written. Precision here determines whether the fee is right, the scope is defensible, and the proposal earns approval.

E.1 Why Discovery Comes First	E.2 Reading RFP & Drawings	E.3 The One Prepared Call
E.4 Five Things to Confirm	E.5 The Questionnaire System	E.6 Questionnaires by Sector
E.7 When Info Is Missing	E.8 Red Flags in Discovery	E.9 Discovery Notes to Proposal
E.10 Saving & Organizing in Box	✓ 15-Question Assessment	◆ Flashcard Grid

WATCH AND LISTEN

Section Briefings

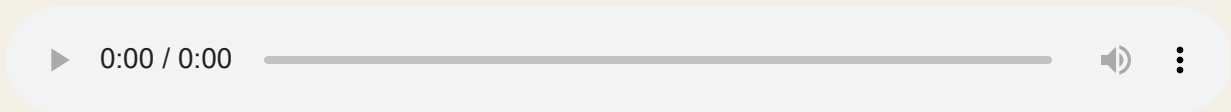
Watch the video, listen to the podcast, then read the module. The same discovery discipline in three formats.

VIDEO · THE EXPLAINER: ANATOMY OF A PROPOSAL



How discovery feeds directly into proposal construction, from verified data to finished document.

AUDIO · HOW TO AVOID MILLION DOLLAR PROJECT MISTAKES



The discovery discipline that protects scope, fee, and client trust, narrated.

MODULE E · CONCEPT MIND MAP



Section E Mind Map

E.1 · WHY DISCOVERY COMES FIRST

Why Discovery Comes Before Everything

Discovery is the intelligence phase of proposal development. It begins the moment a request arrives and ends when you have enough verified information to calculate the fee and write the scope with confidence.

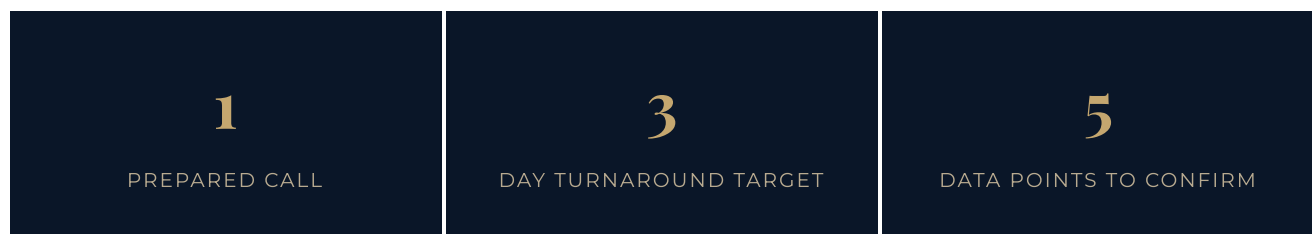
Every cost overrun, every scope dispute, every project that blew past its allotted hours shares a common root cause: a proposal written before the writer fully understood the project. Discovery is not a courtesy step. It is the foundation every downstream decision rests on, from fee calculation to the exact language in the consultation agreement.

At **Create The Edge**, discovery begins the moment the request arrives. Whether it comes as an RFP, an RFQ, a forwarded email from [Company Owner], or a direct architect call, the clock starts. The first job is not to write, not to calculate, and not to call. The first job is to read and understand.

” EXPERT INSIGHT

"So if we have that information, sometimes we have to go in and measure each of these kitchens. Once again, when we collect more data, we can cut and paste and put that square footage in there. But if we don't have that data, sometimes we have to go in to measure those drawings."

· Marketing Director

FIGURE E.1.1 · THE THREE DISCOVERY STANDARDS

The real cost of skipping discovery: a university child development center project where the kitchen grew from 400 square feet to 1,200 square feet after the proposal was already written and accepted. The project team spent 80 hours in schematic design alone, well

beyond the 60 to 70 hours budgeted for the entire engagement. The client resisted paying the overage. Root cause: the proposal was written on an estimate, not verified information.

 RULE OF THE HOUSE

No proposal goes to [Department Manager] for review until all five discovery data points are either confirmed or documented as missing with a benchmark figure substituted. A proposal built on unverified assumptions is not a proposal. It is a liability.

E.2 · READING THE RFP AND DRAWINGS FIRST

Reading the RFP and Drawings First

Before you make a call, before you open a template, before you calculate a fee: read everything the architect or client has sent. Many requests contain all the information you need. Calling without reading first signals you did not review their submission.

FIGURE E.2.1 · WHAT TO HUNT FOR WHEN READING EVERY REQUEST DOCUMENT

WHAT TO FIND	WHY IT MATTERS
Project Type & Sector	Sets the sector rate, template, and fee formula
Square Footage / Kitchen Size	Stated or measurable via BlueBeam; primary fee calculation input
Submission Deadline	Deliver before deadline, not at it
RFP vs. RFQ Signal	Fee request = RFP. Qualifications only = RFQ
Submittal Requirements	Forms and attachments required; missing one = automatic disqualification
Population Driver	FTE, beds, inmates, headcount; drives kitchen sizing
Scope Signals	Full prep, warming only, bar, coffee program included?

Operational Requirements

Meals, shifts, service style

When drawings are attached, use BlueBeam to measure the kitchen footprint directly from the plans. This is the most accurate method when square footage is not stated. Always note whether square footage came from a stated figure or a BlueBeam measurement, because if the project scope changes later, that documentation is your basis for an additional service request.

⚠ WATCH OUT

Do not call the architect to ask for information already in the documents they sent. This signals you did not read the request. It damages credibility before the relationship has begun. Read everything first. Call only if genuinely necessary, and only with a prepared question list.

≡ FROM THE FILES: SQUARE FOOTAGE DISCOVERY IN PRACTICE

A correctional facility proposal arrived with drawings showing 4,001 square feet. The verified inmate count was 490. Applying the benchmark formula (10 sq ft per inmate for populations under 500) produced a calculated need of 4,900 square feet. The discrepancy was documented in the proposal as a discovery note. **Create The Edge** designed to the drawing dimensions while flagging the population-based calculation, protecting the firm if the project expanded.

The One Prepared Call

*Once you have read all available documents and identified what remains unclear, you are ready to call, if a call is necessary. The governing principle at **Create The Edge** is the One Prepared Call: contact the architect or client once, with all questions consolidated and listed in advance.*

You do not call twice because you thought of something else. Multiple calls from the same firm on the same project signal disorganization. Architects work with dozens of consultants; the ones they remember are the ones who are efficient on first contact.

STANDARD ACKNOWLEDGMENT FORMAT

"Thank you for inviting **Create The Edge** to partner with [Firm Name] on [Project Name]. We appreciate the opportunity and will review your information. If we have any questions, we will give you a call."

Send this immediately on receipt, before reading anything. It confirms arrival, signals professionalism, and sets the expectation that any call will be purposeful and prepared.

FIGURE E.3.1 • SHOULD YOU CALL? DECISION FRAMEWORK

1

FIRST

Read All Attached Documents

Stop. Read everything first. Many requests contain all the information you need. Calling without reading signals you did not review their submission.

2

THEN

Unanswered Questions?

If all questions are answered after reading: no call needed, proceed to fee calculation. If gaps remain: consolidate all questions and make ONE prepared call.

BEST PRACTICE: RAPPORT ON THE CALL

"I reviewed your materials thoroughly and we are excited about this project. I have just a few specific questions to make sure our proposal reflects exactly what you need." This signals competence, preparation, and genuine interest in the first sentence.

E.4 · FIVE THINGS EVERY DISCOVERY CALL MUST CONFIRM

Five Things Every Discovery Call Must Confirm

Whether gathered through documents or a call, the fee calculation cannot begin until these five data points are confirmed or replaced with a documented benchmark. A proposal that goes to review without all five addressed will come back.

1

CONFIRMATION POINT

Project Type & Sector

K-12, Healthcare, Correctional, Corporate, other. Drives the template, rate, and formula used for the entire proposal.

2

CONFIRMATION POINT

Population Driver

FTE (K-12), Beds (Healthcare), Inmates (Correctional), Headcount per shift (Corporate). Determines kitchen size when sq footage is unavailable.

3

CONFIRMATION POINT

Square Footage

Stated in request, OR measured via BlueBeam, OR benchmarked from population (~10 sq ft per person, under 500). The fee calculation input.

4

CONFIRMATION POINT

Operational Requirements

Full-prep or warming only? Bar or coffee program? Laundry in scope? These define scope and phases included in the proposal.

5

CONFIRMATION POINT

Deadline & Submittal Requirements

Date and time, delivery method, copies required, required attachments. Deliver before the deadline, not at it. Anchors the three business day internal turnaround target.

SECTOR	POPULATION DRIVER	SIZING BENCHMARK	KEY NOTE
K-12 Education	Full-Time Equivalent (FTE) enrollment	~10 sq ft per person (under 500)	Standardized layouts; 4% fee rate
Healthcare	Licensed beds / avg daily census	Varies by service model	Cook-chill vs. tray-line affects sizing significantly
Correctional	Inmate count / avg daily population	~10 sq ft per inmate (under 500)	Verify against drawings; flag discrepancies
Corporate	Headcount per shift, not total employees	Based on meal participation & service style	Ask shift structure; design for peak period, not total
Hospitality / Events	Seat count / covers per service	Sector rate applied to kitchen sq ft	Service volume determines equipment weight

WATCH OUT: COFFEE PROGRAMS

A "coffee bar" is not a simple add-on. A full espresso program starts at \$80,000 to \$150,000, with an espresso machine alone costing \$35,000 to \$45,000. If the client mentions a coffee bar in passing, clarify immediately: grab-and-go or full espresso service? The scope and fee difference is enormous.

E.5 • THE QUESTIONNAIRE SYSTEM

The Questionnaire System

*For complex projects where a single call cannot gather all required information, **Create The Edge** uses questionnaires: structured documents sent to the architect or client. They are a supplement for projects with too many variables to resolve verbally, not a replacement for the One Prepared Call.*

The governing principle is precision. Vague questions produce vague answers. Vague answers produce assumptions. Assumptions produce errors in the proposal. Every questionnaire question must be specific enough that the recipient can answer it with a concrete fact, number, or decision.

” ON QUESTIONNAIRE PRECISION

"The things that I've learned are to be able to ask more precise, direct questions. Otherwise you get vague information, and then you put yourself into it, and you go, 'Well, this is what I would do.' Whereas if you had the specific information, you could go, 'This is what we should do.'"

· Marketing Director

WHEN TO USE A QUESTIONNAIRE

- The project has multiple service areas with different operational requirements (executive dining plus cafeteria plus catering)
- The request does not specify operational details and the documents do not answer them
- The project involves laundry in addition to foodservice, requiring separate question sets
- The client is the owner directly rather than an architect, and may not know standard AEC terminology

⚠ WATCH OUT: OVER-BURDENING THE ARCHITECT

A 40-question questionnaire sent to an architect on a routine school project signals poor judgment. Architects are managing multiple consultants on tight timelines. Use questionnaires for complex projects only. For straightforward requests, the One Prepared Call is sufficient.

📊 RULE OF THE HOUSE: TEMPLATE INTEGRITY

The master questionnaire template lives in Box > Marketing Proposals > Proposal Templates. Copy it into the specific project folder before making any changes. Any edit made to the master template directly corrupts it for every future project. This rule has no exceptions.

E.6 · CUSTOMIZING QUESTIONNAIRES BY SECTOR

Customizing Questionnaires by Project Type

The master questionnaire contains all possible question categories. Before sending, remove sections that do not apply and add any project-specific questions. A K-12 questionnaire looks nothing like a correctional facility questionnaire.

FIGURE E.6.1 · KEY DISCOVERY QUESTIONS BY SECTOR

SECTOR	CRITICAL QUESTIONS	KEY NOTE
K-12 Education	FTE enrollment? Breakfast, lunch, or both? Serving line or cafeteria? Central cook or satellite warm? New construction or renovation?	Standardized layouts = 4% fee rate
Healthcare	Licensed beds or avg census? Cook-chill or cook-serve? Tray-line or room service? Cafeteria for staff/visitors? Any laundry in scope?	Service model drives equipment selection
Correctional	Average daily inmate count? Rated vs. actual capacity? How many meals per day? Cook-chill or cook-serve? Laundry in scope? Security tier restrictions?	10 sq ft per inmate benchmark (under 500)
Corporate	Total headcount on-site? How many shifts? Meal participation rate? Executive dining required? Coffee bar or grab-and-go? Employee locker rooms?	Shift structure determines peak kitchen demand

A corporate dining project stated 50 employees. A standard questionnaire might calculate for all 50 at once. The actual situation: three separate shifts, maximum 18 employees eating during any one period. Designing for 50 simultaneous diners would have over-specified the kitchen by nearly 200%. The shift question, asked precisely, reduced equipment cost and right-sized the fee to what the project actually required.

MODULE E · DISCOVERY

E.7 · WHEN INFORMATION IS MISSING

When Information Is Missing

Missing information is not a reason to stall. It is a situation with a defined response. At [Create The Edge](#), there are exactly three appropriate responses to missing discovery data, applied in order.

1

RESPONSE ONE

Request It

Ask the architect or client directly. Document the request and date in [CRM Software]. Frame it as a service: "To ensure our proposal reflects your actual project scope rather than a general estimate, we need to confirm [specific item]."

2

RESPONSE TWO

Benchmark It

If the deadline is too tight, apply the appropriate benchmark and document it clearly. For K-12/correctional under 500: multiply population by 10 sq ft. The benchmark figure is always identified as such, never presented as a verified measurement.

3

RESPONSE THREE

Flag It

When you have used a benchmark or estimate, include a discovery note in the proposal. This shows the client Create The Edge is being transparent about the data used, and creates the legal basis for an additional service request if the actual scope differs significantly.

Escalate

IF ALL THREE FAIL

Do Not Proceed Alone

If information is fundamentally missing and no benchmark can responsibly substitute, escalate to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner]. Escalation is not failure; it is the correct professional response.

RULE OF THE HOUSE: DOCUMENT EVERY ASSUMPTION

Any figure in the fee calculation that is a benchmark rather than a verified measurement must be labeled as such. If the actual square footage later differs from the estimate by more than 15%, that documented assumption is your basis for requesting an additional service fee. Without the documentation, you have no basis for the request.

E.8 · RED FLAGS IN DISCOVERY

Red Flags in Discovery

Not every project that arrives is worth pursuing, and not every project worth pursuing is ready to be proposed. Discovery is also an evaluation process.

FIGURE E.8.1 · RED FLAGS VS. CAUTION SIGNALS

CATEGORY	SIGNAL	ACTION
▲ Red Flag	Scope contradicts itself (request says warming kitchen, drawings show full prep)	Escalate to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] before proceeding
▲ Red Flag	Square footage cannot support stated population (490 inmates in 4,001 sq ft; benchmark = 4,900 needed)	Escalate to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] before proceeding
▲ Red Flag	Client is unresponsive near the deadline with key data missing	Escalate to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] before proceeding
▲ Red Flag	Multiple missing data points with no viable benchmark	Escalate to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] before proceeding
► Caution	Client uses wrong terminology	Clarify and educate; may signal unfamiliarity with scope
► Caution	Drawings are preliminary or schematic only	Benchmark from population; flag that dimensions may change
► Caution	Budget mentioned that seems low for scope	Note it; the estimate will confirm or contradict the budget
► Caution	RFP label on what reads like an RFQ	Confirm with architect; respond to content, not the label

■ RULE OF THE HOUSE: ESCALATE, NEVER DECIDE ALONE ON RED FLAGS

When a genuine red flag appears in discovery, bring it to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] before investing additional time. Deciding unilaterally on a red-flag project is not initiative. It is a liability.

MODULE E · APPLICATION

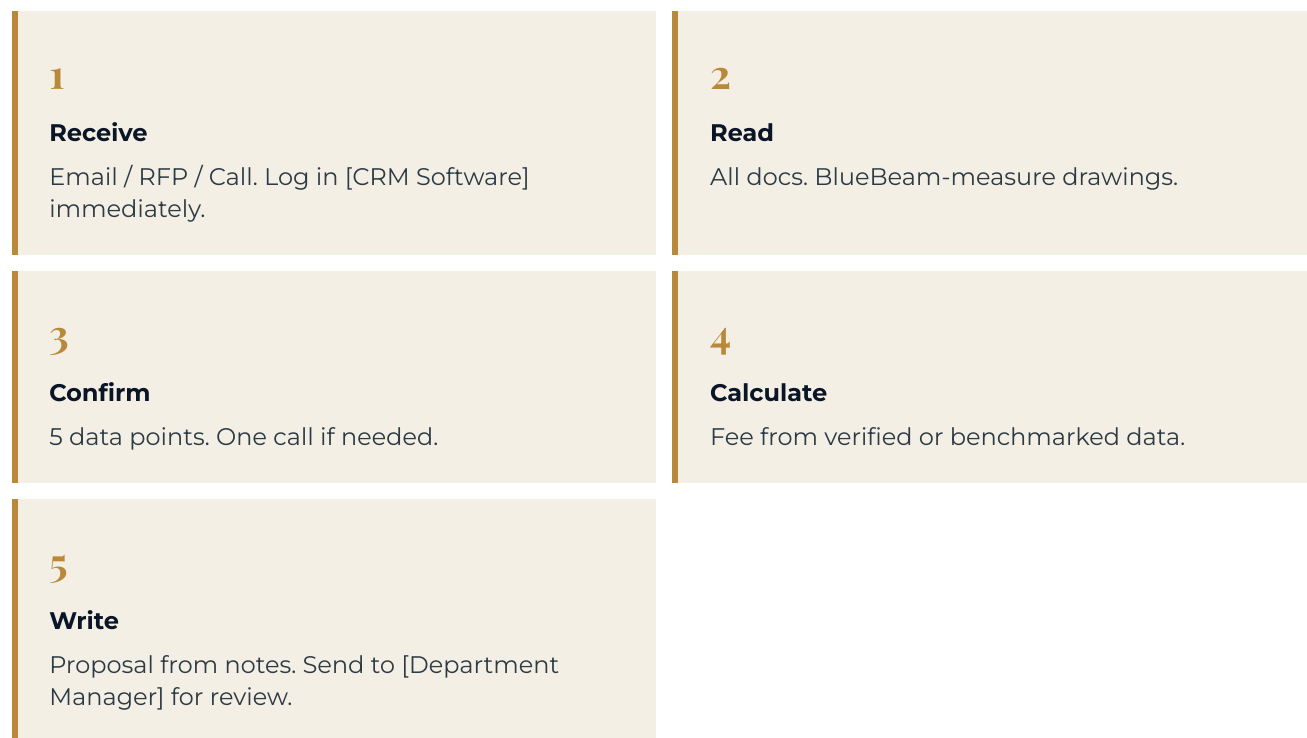
E.9 · HOW DISCOVERY NOTES BECOME THE PROPOSAL

How Discovery Notes Become the Proposal

Discovery is not a phase that ends before the proposal begins. It is the source document for the proposal. Every data point confirmed in discovery has a specific home in the proposal structure.

FIGURE E.9.1 · DISCOVERY DATA MAPPED TO PROPOSAL LOCATION

DISCOVERY DATA POINT	WHERE IT GOES	HOW IT IS USED
Project type and sector	Reference line, cover letter opening	Establishes project identity; drives template selection
Square footage (verified)	Scope narrative, fee calculation basis	Primary driver of equipment cost estimate and fee
Population driver	Problem statement / sizing narrative	Justifies kitchen dimensions; shows you understand the project
Operational requirements	Segment paragraphs (Phase I scope)	Defines what phases and deliverables are included
Benchmark figures (unverified)	Discovery note within scope narrative	Protects firm; creates basis for additional service request
RFP vs. RFQ determination	Response format and folder naming	RFP = full proposal with fee; RFQ = qualifications package



✓ **BEST PRACTICE: THE ONE-PARAGRAPH DISCOVERY SUMMARY**

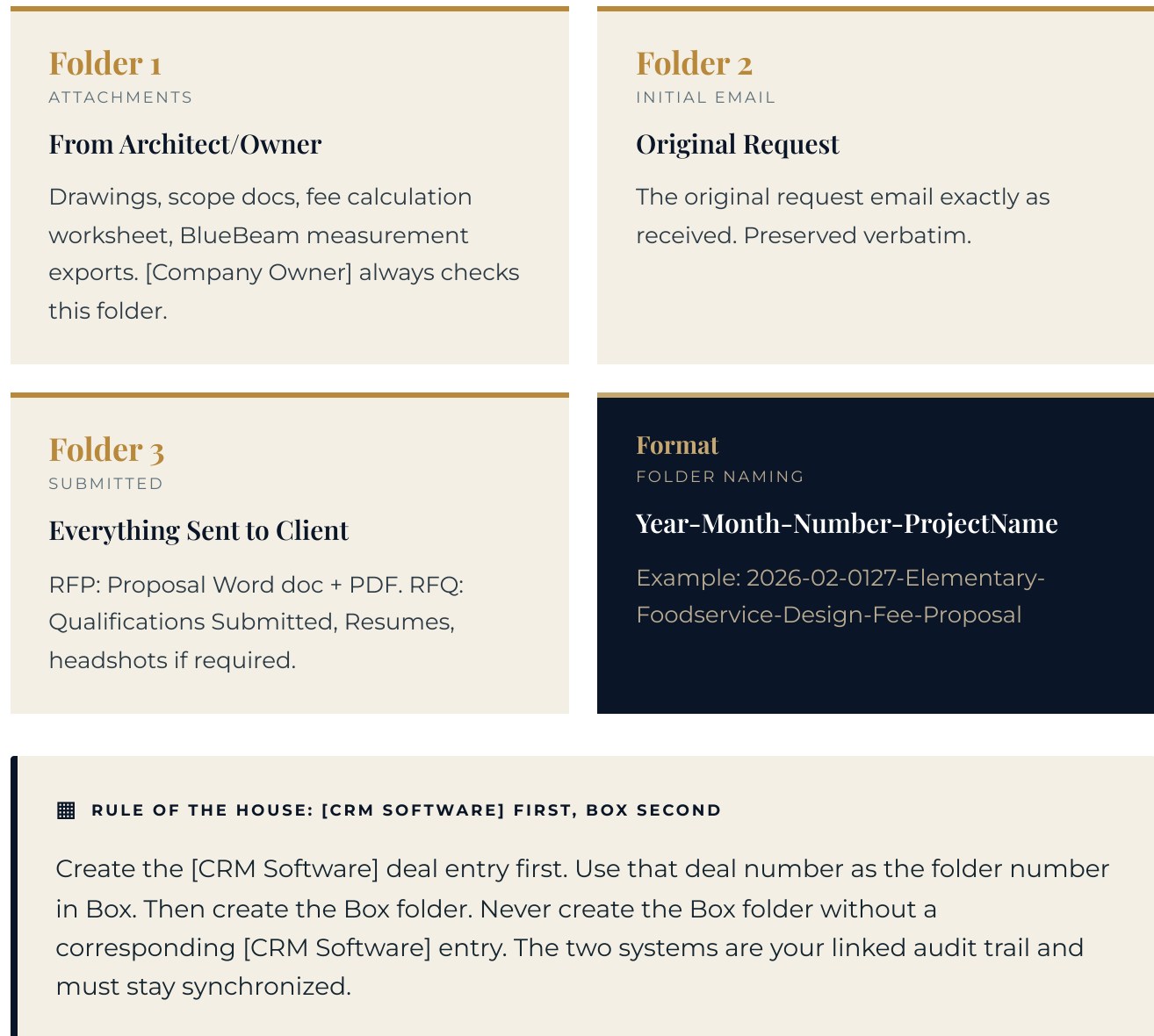
Before starting to write, take five minutes to write a single paragraph summarizing everything confirmed in discovery: project type, population, square footage source, operational scope, and deadline. This summary becomes the first entry in your fee calculation notes. If you cannot write the paragraph without using the word "unknown," you are not ready to write the proposal.

Saving and Organizing in Box

Discovery produces documents: the original request email, drawings, questionnaire responses, BlueBeam measurement exports, and fee calculation notes. All must be saved in the correct Box folder structure before the proposal goes to review.

The organization process follows the same sequence every time: [CRM Software] first, Box second. Create the deal in [CRM Software] before creating the folder in Box. The [CRM Software] deal number becomes part of the Box folder name, creating a linked reference trail that allows anyone on the team to find all project documents from either system.

FIGURE E.10.1 • BOX FOLDER ARCHITECTURE



Navigate to Marketing Proposals > Proposal Templates, copy the foodservice or food & beverage template that matches the project type, paste it into the specific project folder, and rename it following the naming convention. The rule is absolute: you are always working in a copy inside the project folder. The template in the Templates folder is never edited directly.

MODULE E · ASSESSMENT

✓ COMPREHENSIVE TEST

Information Gathering & Discovery: Assessment

15 questions progressing from Knowledge through Application to Judgment. Do not check answers until you have completed the entire test.

E.1

What is the primary purpose of the discovery phase at **Create The Edge**?

- ☐ A To build rapport with the architect before sending a proposal
- ☐ B To gather verified information that makes the fee accurate and the scope defensible
- ☐ C To determine whether to use a questionnaire or a direct call
- ☐ D To identify which team member will write the proposal

E.2

When a request arrives labeled "RFP" in the email subject line, what actually determines whether it is an RFP or RFQ?

- ☐ A The government agency that issued it
- ☐ B Whether the architect is a known or new contact
- ☐ C The content of the request: if it asks for a fee it is an RFP; if qualifications only it is an RFQ
- ☐ D The length of the document; longer documents are typically RFQs

E.3

What software does **Create The Edge** use to measure kitchen square footage from drawings when it is not stated in the request?

- ☐ A AutoCAD
- ☐ B Revit
- ☐ C AutoQuotes
- ☐ D BlueBeam

E.4

What is the "One Prepared Call" principle?

- ☐ A Always schedule a formal introduction call before reading the RFP
- ☐ B If a call is necessary, make one contact with all questions consolidated in advance
- ☐ C Call the client once before and once after sending the proposal
- ☐ D Prepare one paragraph of notes before any client interaction

E.5

What is the square footage benchmark formula for K-12 and correctional projects with populations under 500?

- ☐ A 15 square feet per person
- ☐ B 5 square feet per person
- ☐ C 10 square feet per person
- ☐ D 12 square feet per person

E.6

What is the population driver for healthcare facilities when sizing the kitchen?

- ☐ A Full-time equivalent (FTE) staff count
- ☐ B Total number of parking spaces
- ☐ C Licensed beds or average daily census
- ☐ D Square footage of the building footprint

E.7

A correctional facility request shows drawings with 4,001 square feet and an inmate count of 490. Applying the benchmark, the calculated need is 4,900 sq ft. What should you do?

- ☐ A Use 4,001 sq ft as stated; drawings are authoritative
- ☐ B Use 4,900 sq ft and do not mention the discrepancy
- ☐ C Design to the drawing dimensions (4,001 sq ft), document the benchmark need (4,900 sq ft), and flag the discrepancy in the proposal as a discovery note
- ☐ D Escalate to [Department Manager] immediately without attempting any calculation

E.8

A client casually mentions they want "a coffee bar" in their corporate cafeteria. What is the correct discovery response?

- ☐ A Include a standard coffee station in scope and note it as a minor addition
- ☐ B Clarify immediately: grab-and-go setup or a full espresso program? The scope difference is \$80,000 to \$150,000
- ☐ C Assume they mean a simple drip coffee machine and price accordingly
- ☐ D Exclude it from scope and add as an optional alternate phase

E.9

You have read all documents and have no remaining questions. Should you call the architect?

- ☐ A Yes, always call to build the relationship before sending the proposal
- ☐ B Yes, but only to confirm the submission deadline
- ☐ C No, if you have all the information you need, a call is not required; proceed to fee calculation
- ☐ D No, but send a questionnaire to double-confirm everything

E.10

You have a verified population of 650 students for a K-12 project but no drawings and no stated square footage. What is the correct next step?

- ☐ A Decline the proposal until drawings are provided
- ☐ B Apply 10 sq ft per student as a benchmark (6,500 sq ft), document it as an estimate, and flag it in the proposal
- ☐ C Use the average K-12 kitchen size of 3,000 sq ft regardless of enrollment
- ☐ D Ask the architect to provide drawings before doing any calculation

E.11

In what order should you create records when a new proposal request arrives?

- ☐ A Box folder first, then [CRM Software] entry
- ☐ B [CRM Software] deal first, then Box folder using the [CRM Software] number
- ☐ C Fee calculation first, then both systems simultaneously
- ☐ D Proposal draft first, then file in Box when complete

E.12

A request has two red flags: contradictory scope and the client has not responded in four days with two days until deadline. What is the correct response?

- ☐ A Write the proposal based on your best interpretation of the scope
- ☐ B Decline the project and remove it from [CRM Software]
- ☐ C Escalate to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] immediately; do not proceed without their input
- ☐ D Submit the proposal with a note that some information was unavailable

E.13

Your fee calculation used a benchmark of 4,500 sq ft. After acceptance, revised drawings show 7,200 sq ft. What protects **Create The Edge**'s right to request an additional service fee?

- ☐ A Verbal agreement made during the discovery call
- ☐ B The documented benchmark figure and discovery note in the original proposal
- ☐ C Standard industry practice for scope changes
- ☐ D The fact that the client never questioned the fee during review

E.14

A corporate client says 50 employees and everyone eats lunch together at noon. During discovery you learn they run three shifts, 18 employees per shift at staggered periods. How does this affect the proposal?

- ☐ A No change; design for peak capacity of 50
- ☐ B Reduce scope significantly; peak demand is 18, not 50, changing equipment weight and fee
- ☐ C Add a separate dining area for each shift, increasing the scope
- ☐ D Use the client's original statement of 50 to avoid confusion

E.15

Mid-proposal you discover the project includes a full espresso program, mentioned only casually in the original request. The fee you calculated does not account for this. What is the correct action?

- ☐ A Submit the proposal as calculated and address the espresso scope when the project begins
- ☐ B Recalculate the fee to include the espresso program, update the proposal, and submit to [Department Manager] for review before sending
- ☐ C Include the espresso bar in scope but keep the same fee to protect the client relationship
- ☐ D Exclude the espresso bar entirely without mentioning it

☑ ANSWER LEGEND • PART 1 OF 2

Answers • E.1 through E.8

Do not review until the test is complete.

E.1

Correct: B • Gather verified information that makes the fee accurate and the scope defensible

Discovery's purpose is to gather verified information. Rapport building is a benefit, not the primary purpose. See E.1.

E.2

Correct: C • Content of the request: fee request = RFP; qualifications only = RFQ

The content determines the type, not the label. Architects frequently mislabel these documents. Read the body and the attachment, find out whether a fee is being requested. See E.2.

E.3

Correct: D • BlueBeam

BlueBeam is Create The Edge's measurement tool for reading kitchen square footage from drawings. AutoCAD and Revit are design tools. AutoQuotes is used for equipment cost estimation. See E.2.

E.4

Correct: B • If a call is necessary, make one contact with all questions consolidated in advance

Multiple calls from the same firm on the same project signal disorganization. Architects work with dozens of consultants. The ones they remember are the ones who are efficient on first contact. See E.3.

E.5

Correct: C • 10 square feet per person

The Create The Edge benchmark for K-12 and correctional facilities with populations under 500 is approximately 10 square feet per person. This is the standard formula applied when drawings are unavailable. See E.4.

E.6

Correct: C • Licensed beds or average daily census

Healthcare kitchen sizing is driven by licensed beds or average daily census. The dietary service model also factors in, but the population driver is bed count. See E.4.

E.7

Correct: C · Design to drawing dimensions, document benchmark, flag discrepancy in proposal

490 x 10 sq ft = 4,900 sq ft benchmark. Correct response: design to the drawing dimensions, document the benchmark need, and flag the discrepancy in the proposal as a discovery note. See E.2 and E.7.

E.8

Correct: B · Clarify immediately: grab-and-go or full espresso program? The scope difference is \$80,000 to \$150,000

A full espresso program costs \$80,000-\$150,000, with the machine alone at \$35,000-\$45,000. Clarify immediately. Assuming without asking is precisely the error discovery is designed to prevent. See E.4.

MODULE E · ASSESSMENT

☑ ANSWER LEGEND · PART 2 OF 2

Answers · E.9 through E.15

The remaining answers with reasoning and sub-module cross-references.

E.9

Correct: C · No, if you have all information, a call is not required; proceed to fee calculation

If all information is available from documents, a call is not required. The decision framework is explicit: call only if there are unanswered questions after reading everything. See E.3.

E.10

Correct: B · Apply 10 sq ft per student as a benchmark (6,500 sq ft), document it, and flag it in the proposal

650 x 10 = 6,500 sq ft benchmark. Apply the formula, document it as an estimate, and flag it in the proposal. The benchmark exists precisely for this situation. See E.7.

E.11

Correct: B · [CRM Software] deal first, then Box folder using the [CRM Software] number

[CRM Software] first, Box second. The [CRM Software] deal number becomes the Box folder number, creating a linked audit trail. Reversing the sequence breaks the synchronization. See E.10.

E.12

Correct: C · Escalate to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] immediately; do not proceed without their input

Two genuine red flags near a deadline require escalation, not unilateral action. Deciding alone on a red-flag project is not initiative. It is a liability. See E.8.

E.13

Correct: B · The documented benchmark figure and discovery note in the original proposal

The documented benchmark figure and discovery note in the original proposal are the legal basis for requesting an additional service fee. Without this written record, there is no documentation that the original fee was based on a specific stated assumption. See E.7.

E.14

Correct: B · Reduce scope significantly; peak demand is 18, not 50

Peak demand is 18, not 50. Designing for 50 simultaneous diners over-specifies the kitchen by nearly 200%. The shift structure question is exactly why discovery matters: the client's initial statement was incorrect. See E.6.

E.15

Correct: B · Recalculate the fee to include the espresso program and submit to [Department Manager] for review

A full espresso program adds significant scope and cost. Recalculate the fee before the proposal goes to [Department Manager]. Submitting an under-priced proposal is not a relationship move; it is a financial and professional error. See E.4.

MODULE E · STUDY TOOLS

◆ FLASHCARDS · REFERENCE GRID

Fifteen Cards · Front and Back

Fifteen flashcards covering the key frameworks, rules, and benchmarks from Section E. Review at Day 1, 3, 7, and 21.

1

The One Prepared Call

If a call is necessary after reading all documents, make one contact with every question consolidated in advance. Multiple

2

Five Discovery Confirmation Points

Project type, population driver, square footage, operational requirements, deadline and submission requirements. All five must be

calls signal disorganization. Read everything first; call only if gaps remain.

(E.3)

confirmed or benchmarked before writing the proposal.

(E.4)

3 BlueBeam

Software used to measure kitchen square footage from drawings when dimensions are not stated. Results feed the fee calculation. Always note whether sq footage is stated or measured.

(E.2)

4 10 Sq Ft Benchmark

For K-12 and correctional facilities with populations under 500, multiply population by 10 to estimate kitchen size. Always document it as a benchmark, not a verified measurement.

(E.4)

5 Population Drivers by Sector

K-12: FTE enrollment. Healthcare: Licensed beds/avg daily census. Correctional: inmate count. Corporate: headcount per shift (not total). Drives kitchen sizing.

(E.4)

6 Standard Acknowledgment

"Thank you for inviting Create The Edge to partner with [Firm] on [Project]. We will review. If we have questions, we will call." Send this before reading anything. Sets professional tone immediately.

(E.3)

7 Three Responses to Missing Info

1. Request it from the client and document the request. 2. Apply a sector benchmark and document the calculation. 3. Flag it in the proposal as a discovery note. Apply in order.

(E.7)

8 Coffee Bar Scope Rule

A full espresso program starts at \$80,000-\$150,000. The machine alone is \$35,000-\$45,000. Always clarify grab-and-go vs. full espresso service. Never assume "coffee bar" means simple.

(E.4)

9 Box Three Subfolders

Every project: (1) Attachments from architect/owner, (2) Initial Email, (3) Submitted (everything that went to the client). RFQ uses "Qualifications Submitted" for folder 3.

(E.10)

10 [CRM Software] First, Box Second

Create the [CRM Software] deal before the Box folder. The [CRM Software] number becomes the Box folder number (e.g., 2026-02-0127). Links both systems into a synchronized, searchable audit trail.

(E.10)

11 Red Flag Escalation Rule

Contradictory scope, population that cannot fit sq footage, unresponsive client near deadline, multiple missing data points: bring to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] before investing further time.

12 Benchmark Documentation Rule

Any figure used as a benchmark must be labeled as such in both the fee calculation notes and the proposal. This is the legal basis for additional service fee requests if scope changes.

(E.8)

(E.7)

13

Discovery-to-Proposal Mapping

Square footage drives fee. Population justifies scope narrative. Operational requirements define phases. Benchmarks go in discovery notes. Red flags go to leadership, not in the proposal text.

(E.9)

14

Template Copy Rule

Always copy the master template from Box Proposal Templates into the project folder before editing. Never edit the master directly. One edit corrupts all future projects starting from that template.

(E.5)

15

Shift Structure Question

Always ask how many shifts and how many people per shift for corporate and correctional projects. Peak demand per shift, not total headcount, determines kitchen sizing. 50 total on 3 shifts = design for ~17, not 50.

(E.6)

MODULE E · STUDY TOOLS

▣ FLASHCARDS · INTERACTIVE

Tap the Card to See the Answer

Fifteen cards, one at a time. Read the front, attempt the back from memory, then tap to check.

TERM · TAP TO REVEAL

The One Prepared Call

Tap card to flip · Use arrows to navigate

← PREVIOUS

1 of 15

NEXT →

✂️ PRINTABLE CUT-OUT STUDY CARDS

Print, Cut, Carry

Fifteen cards arranged for printing. Cut along the borders. Keep them on your desk.

The One Prepared Call

If a call is necessary, make one contact with all questions consolidated. Multiple calls signal disorganization. Read everything first; call only if gaps remain.

Five Discovery Confirmation Points

Project type, population driver, square footage, operational requirements, deadline. All five confirmed or benchmarked before writing the proposal.

BlueBeam

Software used to measure kitchen square footage from drawings. Always note whether sq footage is stated or measured via BlueBeam.

10 Sq Ft Benchmark

K-12 and correctional under 500: multiply population x 10. Always document as a benchmark, not a verified measurement.

Population Drivers

K-12: FTE. Healthcare: Licensed beds. Correctional: inmate count. Corporate: headcount per shift (not total). Drives kitchen sizing.

Standard Acknowledgment

"Thank you for inviting Create The Edge to partner on [Project]. We will review. If we have questions, we will call." Send before reading anything.

Three Responses to Missing Info

1. Request it. 2. Benchmark it (document the calculation). 3. Flag it in the proposal. Apply in order; escalate if all three fail.

Coffee Bar Scope Rule

Full espresso program: \$80K-\$150K. Machine alone: \$35K-\$45K. Always clarify grab-and-go vs. full espresso. Never assume.

Box Three Subfolders

1. Attachments (drawings, fee calc). 2. Initial Email. 3. Submitted (everything sent to client).
[CRM Software] deal number = Box folder number.

[CRM Software] First, Box Second

Create [CRM Software] deal before Box folder. Use [CRM Software] number as Box folder number. Format: 2026-02-0127-ProjectName. Links both systems.

Red Flag Escalation Rule

Contradictory scope, population/sq ft mismatch, unresponsive client near deadline, multiple missing data points: bring to [Department Manager] or [Company Owner]. Never decide alone.

Benchmark Documentation Rule

Any benchmark figure must be labeled as such in fee notes AND proposal text. This is the legal basis for additional service fee requests if scope changes.

Discovery-to-Proposal Mapping

Sq footage drives fee. Population justifies scope. Operational req. define phases. Benchmarks in discovery notes. Red flags to leadership only.

Template Copy Rule

Always copy master template from Box to project folder before editing. Never edit the master directly. One edit corrupts all future proposals.

Shift Structure Question

Always ask: how many shifts? How many per shift? Peak demand per shift determines kitchen sizing. 50 total on 3 shifts = design for ~17, not 50.

Strategic Project Discovery

The complete presentation for this module. Each slide is embedded directly. Scroll through all 15 slides below.

